

OPTIONAL SKIRMISHING RULE

Commanded shot before the main engagement

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Purpose

This optional rule represents the loose exchange of fire by commanded bodies of musketeers before the main bodies became fully engaged. It adds limited probing and reaction fire without changing the normal combat system. A skirmish may create an opportunity, but another unit must be positioned to exploit it before the dice are rolled.

Optional Rule

1. Eligibility and timing

At the beginning of a friendly March Phase, each friendly leader may designate one ordered Foot unit of the same force (color) in its own or an adjacent hex. A Foot unit may not be designated twice. The designated unit must remain in its hex and may not otherwise move during that March Phase. For example, Rupert and Byron could designate one unit each (two total).

The player also designates an ordered enemy unit exactly two hexes away as the target. The target may not be in a close, train, or woods hex. Leaders, artillery pieces, and trains may neither initiate nor be targeted.

Skirmishing is permitted only during Game Turns 1–7 of the full game. It is not used in the Short Game. No skirmishes may be declared during a flash-rain turn [5.4].

An enemy unit may be selected as the target of no more than one skirmish in a March Phase.

2. Placing the marker

Place a **Skirmish** marker in an empty hex adjacent to both the designated Foot unit and its target. The marker represents the ground temporarily occupied by troops sent forward for the exchange; the Foot unit itself does not move.

Other friendly units may move through the marked hex normally, but may not end their movement there. The marker is not a unit and has no Zone of Control. Complete all ordinary movement before rolling any skirmish dice.

3. Resolving skirmishes

After all ordinary movement in the March Phase is complete, resolve declared skirmishes one at a time in any order chosen by the active player:

1. The skirmishing unit fires at its declared target, and the target makes a **Reaction Roll**. Roll one die for each unit and consult the **6+** column of the Artillery Table [17.2]. Other artillery rules do not apply: the designation and marker establish eligibility, and no line of sight or range is traced.
2. Record both results, but do not apply either result yet. The two attacks are simultaneous; a result suffered by one unit

never cancels its own fire.

3. Apply both recorded results simultaneously, then remove the marker. A **Dd** result disrupts an ordered target; a dash has no effect.

A Reaction Roll is not always literal return fire. For Foot it represents return musketry; for Horse it may represent pistol or carbine fire, or a short countercharge. Horse may be a target, but may not initiate a skirmish.

4. After the exchange

The March Phase ends after all marked skirmishes have been resolved. No unit may move in response to a skirmish result. Proceed to the active player's Combat Phase normally. Thus, a unit already positioned to attack may exploit a newly disrupted enemy, but the active player cannot first see the result and then move up an attacker.

The marker does not create adjacency or require either unit to attack. All mandatory-attack requirements are determined from the units' actual positions at the beginning of the ensuing Combat Phase [9.0].

Skirmish Fire: 6+ Column

Die Roll	Result
1	Dd—target disrupted
2–6	—no effect

Rules References

March Phase movement: [8.0]. Artillery die-roll procedure and table: [7.0], [17.2]. Disruption: [11.8]. Short Game: [16.0].

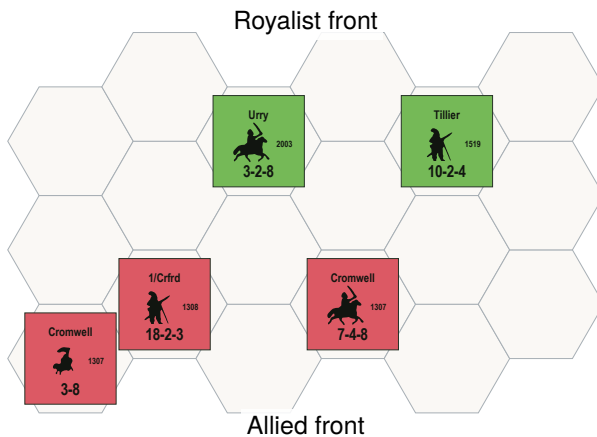
Design Intent

The idea here is to show some level of skirmishing at this scale while preventing unrealistic combined arms attacks, so any Horse waiting to exploit a disruption must be committed first. Most exchanges will do nothing, but occasionally one will open a useful opportunity. Think of this as an amalgam of skirmishing, advancing fire and retreating fire from something like GMT's Musket & Pike series.

Illustrated Example of Play

All illustrated hexes are clear terrain. At the beginning of an Allied March Phase, the **Cromwell** leader designates **1/Crfrd** to skirmish with **Urry**. Cromwell's Heavy Horse is nearby, but its movement must be committed before the skirmish dice are rolled.

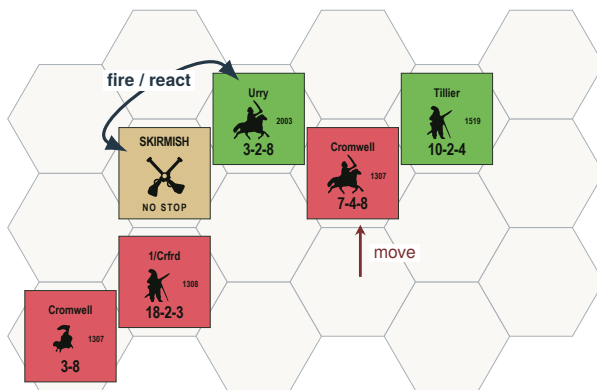
Before: the Allied player plans the probe



The Cromwell leader designates 1/Crfrd, an ordered Foot unit of his force that begins adjacent to him. Urry is exactly two hexes away, with an empty hex between the two units, so it is an eligible target.

The Allied player intends to place the Skirmish marker in that empty hex. Tillier is not the declared target.

During: movement is completed, then fire is exchanged

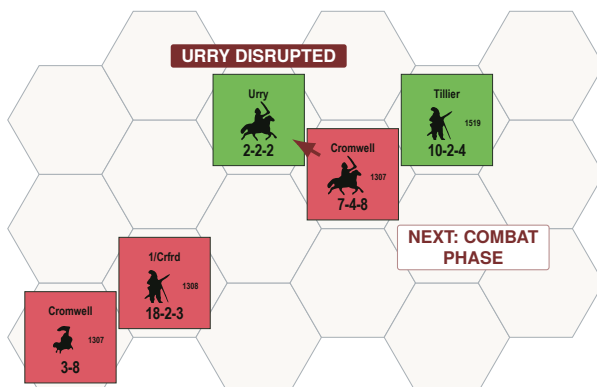


The marker is placed in the intervening hex, while 1/Crfrd remains in its original hex. Other Allied units could pass through the marked hex, but none may end its movement there. Cromwell's Heavy Horse moves adjacent to Urry; all other Allied movement then ends. Both sides now roll on the 6+ column:

- 1/Crfrd rolls **1: Dd** against Urry.
- Urry's Reaction Roll is **4**: no effect against 1/Crfrd.

The results are recorded but not yet applied.

After: apply the results and remove the marker



The recorded results are applied simultaneously: 1/Crfrd remains ordered and Urry is flipped to its disrupted side. The Skirmish marker is removed.

The Allied Combat Phase now begins. Cromwell's Heavy Horse is already adjacent and must attack normally. It may exploit Urry's disruption because its charge was positioned before the successful skirmish roll. No additional Allied movement is permitted.

The diagrams illustrate timing, not a historical deployment or exact map position.